

DAY 23 / 30

SUMMIT RIDGE · ML ENGINEERING

Feature engineering: making raw data model-ready

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Raw data almost never comes in a form a model learns well from. Feature engineering is the craft of reshaping it so the patterns are easier for the model to find.

- ◆ Encoding categories as numbers — a model can't take "red/green/blue" directly; it needs a numeric representation.
- ◆ Scaling — putting features like "age" (0-100) and "income" (0-500,000) on comparable scales so one doesn't dominate purely due to magnitude.
- ◆ Creating derived features — "days since last purchase" is often far more predictive than raw purchase timestamps on their own; the model doesn't have to discover that transformation itself.
- ◆ Handling missing data thoughtfully — deleting, filling, or explicitly flagging gaps, depending on why the data is missing.

“Deep learning and LLMs shift some of this burden onto the model itself — but for structured business data, this skill is still core to the job.”

Follow along – Day 24 drops tomorrow.

#MachineLearning

#DataScience

#FeatureEngineering

#AI